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Dating Preferences of University Women: An Analysis of the Nice Guy Stereotype

EDWARD S. HEROLD and ROBIN R. MILHAUSEN
University of Guelph, Ontario, Canada

Many researchers have attempted to discover what types of men women consider most desirable for relationship partners. This study investigated university women's (N = 165) perceptions of "nice guys," specifically whether women perceived nice guys to be more or less sexually successful than guys who are considered not nice. Both quantitative and qualitative analyses were used. The qualitative analysis was useful in understanding women's differing interpretations of the nice guy label. More than one half of the women agreed that nice guys have fewer sexual partners. However, more than one half also reported a preference for a nice guy over a bad boy as a date. As hypothesized, women who placed a lesser emphasis on the importance of sex, who had fewer sexual partners, and who were less accepting of men who had many sexual partners were more likely to choose the nice guy as a dating partner. The findings indicate that nice guys are likely to have fewer sexual partners but are more desired for committed relationships.

What types of men are attractive to women? Do nice guys finish last in the sexual marketplace? Research has provided inconsistent answers to these questions. Qualities associated with "nice guys," such as understanding, considerateness, kindness, dependability, and honesty, are often reported as preferable in marriage partners (Buss & Barnes, 1986). In a study of minimum mate selection standards, Regan (1998) found that women required higher levels of agreeableness (attentiveness to partner's needs, kindness and understanding, honesty and trustworthiness) in a marriage partner than any other attribute studied, while they ranked dominance as the least important trait. In a study of desired characteristics in a sexual and marriage partner, Regan and Berscheid (1997) also found women desired honesty, trustworthiness, and sensitivity above all other characteristics in a spouse. However, different characteristics were preferred for short-term and sexual partners (for example,

Address correspondence to Edward S. Herold, Department of Family Relations and Applied Nutrition, University of Guelph, ON, Canada, N1G 2W1. E-mail: eherold@facs.uoguelph.ca

physical attractiveness (Regan, 1998; Regan & Berscheid, 1997). In other research, feminine men possessing high levels of kindness and warmth were found to be the most preferred as friends and romantic partners (Desrochers, 1995).

However, some researchers have found women to prefer dominant males characterized by high levels of assertiveness, confidence, and high financial and social status. For example, Sadalla, Kenrick, and Vershure (1987) found that male dominance enhanced a woman's rating of a man's sexual attractiveness. Buss and Schmitt (1993) also concluded that a man's ability to accrue resources was important to women's desiring either a short- or long-term relationship. Ambition, industry, income, and status were all considered observable cues to a mate's potential value. Similarly, Botwin, Buss, and Shackelford (1997) reported the themes of power, social ascendance, and resource acquisition to be more prevalent in women's preferences for potential mates than in men's.

In attempting to integrate findings suggesting that dominant as well as nice men are desired by women, Jensen-Campell, Graziano, and West (1995) hypothesized that a man's prosocial orientation would increase his desirability as a date, if his prosocial behavior were seen as deriving from a position of dominance. Their results supported this hypothesis, as men who were rated as highly agreeable were considered by women to be more physically and sexually attractive if they were also dominant. Dominance, independent of agreeableness, had no effect on desirability.

In studying women's partner preferences, most researchers have relied on checklist surveys or ranking procedures to determine women's preferences (Botwin et al., 1997; Buss & Barnes, 1986; Regan, 1998; Regan & Berscheid, 1997). However, few researchers have surveyed men regarding their actual experiences. In one survey of men, Trapnell and Meston (1996) found that nice guys who were modest, agreeable, and unselfish were disadvantaged in sexual relationships. Men who were manipulative, arrogant, calculating, and sly were more sexually active and had a greater variety of sexual experiences and a greater number of sex partners. These men scored higher on the agentic facets of an extraversion scale, namely assertiveness, activity level, and excitement seeking. These dimensions were correlated more highly with sexual experience than other communal variables such as warmth and positive emotion. Similarly, Bogaert and Fisher (1995), in attempting to predict number of sexual partners among university men, found that sensation seeking, hypermasculine sex role, positive sexual affect, testosterone, psychoticism, physical attractiveness, and dominance were all positively correlated with the men's lifetime number of sexual partners. Intimacy and closeness were negatively correlated with number of sex partners both during a one-month period and over the subjects' lifetimes. Also, men who advocated an unrestricted sociosexual orientation, involving a willingness to engage in uncommitted sexual relations, described themselves as assertive, irresponsible, and not warm (Reise & Wright, 1996).

There is an obvious discrepancy in these research findings. Nice guys, who are sensitive, patient, and nurturing, appear to be favored by many

women (Buss & Barnes, 1986; Regan, 1998; Regan & Berscheid, 1997). However, men who are dominant, confident, and aggressive have reported the most sexual success with women (Reise & Wright, 1996; Trapnell & Meston, 1996). The sexual strategies derived from evolutionary theory can be used to explain the potential appeal of both nice guys and not-so-nice guys (whom we labeled as bad boys). Both types of men may contribute, in differing ways, to the survival of the offspring they create.

According to the evolutionary perspective, women develop psychological mechanisms through natural selection that maximize the survival of the species by supporting reproductive functions (Weiderman, 1993). These psychological mechanisms are the guiding forces behind the sexual selection processes. Women use one of two different strategies when choosing a potential mate; these strategies are referred to as sociosexual orientations (Gangestad & Simpson, 1990; Simpson & Gangestad, 1992). The first strategy, a restricted sociosexual orientation, involves selecting a mate who is willing and able to invest in her offspring. Women who choose mates using this strategy tend to endorse a more conservative pattern of sexual behavior, seeking greater evidence of paternal investment before sexual involvement (Simpson & Gangestad, 1992). The second strategy, labeled an unrestricted sociosexual orientation, is characterized by women's selecting a partner for his possession of important attributes or resources which can be handed down to offspring through genetics or socialization. Here women would evaluate partner suitability on the basis of such characteristics as social dominance and physical attractiveness. As women who adopt an unrestricted sociosexual orientation are not looking for paternal investment or long-term involvement with a partner, they are more willing to engage in uncommitted sexual relations and more likely to have many sexual partners (Simpson & Gangestad, 1992). Simpson and Gangestad found that mate preferences did indeed load on one of two factors. The first factor, labeled personal/parenting qualities, included the attributes of kindness, understanding, faithfulness, and loyalty. The second factor, labeled attractiveness/social visibility, included the attributes of physical attractiveness, sex appeal, financial resources, and social status. Simpson and Gangestad gave women profiles of men fitting each of the two character types and asked them to choose which one was more appealing. Women who were classified as having a restricted sociosexual orientation were more likely to prefer the man who was described as "average looking, stable and responsible, caring, dependable, and faithful" (Simpson & Gangestad, 1992, p. 40). Women who were classified as unrestricted were more likely to prefer the man described as "sexy, confident (even arrogant), not known for living a responsible lifestyle, and of questionable faithfulness" (Simpson & Gangestad, 1992, p. 39).

One major limitation of the research on mating preferences is the use of checklist format questionnaires, which ask participants to rank desired characteristics (Botwin et al., 1997; Buss & Barnes, 1986; Regan, 1998; Regan & Berscheid, 1997). Herold (1974) suggested that checklist-type questions may be susceptible to a social desirability bias. As well, this

methodology may be artificial as it measures idealized partner characteristics rather than actual partner choices. A second limitation is that while researchers have provided theoretical explanations for women's choice of partner characteristics, they have neglected to actually ask women about their motivations in making such choices.

The objective of the research reported here was to study women's perceptions of the sexual success and dating desirability of nice guys. Qualitative analysis was used to obtain a more in-depth understanding as to why nice guys are seen to be more or less sexually successful with women.

The women's own dating preferences were also studied on the basis of previous research that used women's sociosexual orientation (Reise & Wright, 1996; Simpson & Gangestad, 1992) as a predictor for partner choice. It was hypothesized that a preference for nice guys as dating partners would be related to the women's rating of the importance of sex, their number of previous sexual partners, and their acceptance of men's having many sex partners. Specifically, it was hypothesized that women who placed a lesser emphasis on sex, who had fewer previous sexual partners, and who were not accepting of men who had many previous sex partners would prefer to date nice guys.

METHOD

Subjects

Subjects who volunteered to take part in this study involved a convenience sample of 174 female undergraduate students enrolled in a first year course on couple and family relations. Nine of the women indicated they were lesbian or bisexual, and they were not included in the analysis, thus reducing the sample to 165. The students ranged in age from 18 to 25 ($M = 19.6$, $SD = 1.2$). Thirty-eight percent of the women had not dated in the last four weeks and 44% were involved in a steady relationship with only one partner. About one third (32%) had not experienced sexual intercourse, 27% had had one sexual partner, 25% had two or three partners, and 16% had four or more partners.

Measures

Sexual importance. Women were asked: "How important is sex to you?" Responses were: (a) Very important, (b) Somewhat important, (c) Of little importance, and (d) Not important.

Maximum acceptable level of partner's sexual experience. To measure the women's acceptable upper limits in terms of a potential partner's level of sexual experience, they were asked to fill in the blank in this statement: "I would prefer not to date someone who has had more than _____ partners." To determine whether women's behavior in selecting partners differed from their reported preferences, they were asked: "Have you

dated someone in the past who had had more sexual partners than you would have liked?" Responses included: (a) Yes or (b) No.

Women's perceptions of nice guys. Three items were constructed to measure women's perceptions and preferences regarding nice guys. The first item measured the women's own preferences for a dating partner: "You meet two men. One, John, is nice but somewhat shy. He has not had any sexual experience. The other, Mike, is attractive, a lot of fun, and has had intercourse with 10 women. Both wish to date you. Whom do you choose?" Response choices were: (a) Definitely John, (b) Most likely John, (c) Equally prefer John or Mike, (d) Most likely Mike, and (e) Definitely Mike). In constructing this item we followed Sprecher, Regan, McKinney, Maxwell, and Wazienski's (1997) suggestion that number of partners should be analyzed in conjunction with other traits. Thus, we balanced the potential negative evaluation of Mike's having had several sexual partners with positive characteristics that might be appealing to women, especially to those having an unrestricted sociosexual orientation. The second item measured the women's perceptions of their peers' choices regarding dating partners: "Do you know of women who have had the choice of dating nice but sexually inexperienced men but chose to date men who are very sexually experienced but not as nice?" Response categories included: (a) Yes, several women, (b) Yes, a few women, and (c) No. Finally, the third item measured the women's perceptions of the sexual success of nice guys: "You may have heard the expression, 'Nice guys finish last.' In terms of dating, and sex, do you think women are less likely to have sex with men who are 'nice' than men who are 'not nice'?" Responses were: (a) Definitely yes, (b) Probably yes, (c) Probably not, and (d) Definitely not. To determine women's perceptions of why nice guys may or may not be less sexually successful than not-so-nice guys, women were asked in an open-ended question to explain their answer. Content analysis was used to gain in-depth insight into women's perceptions regarding this question.

Pretest

The questionnaire was pretested on 15 female undergraduate students before its administration to the main sample. Changes in the wording of the questions were made on the basis of feedback from the respondents.

Procedure

The research was conducted during regular class time. The researchers stated that the study focused on the sexual attitudes of single, heterosexual women. Subjects were asked to read an information sheet and complete a consent form before filling out the questionnaire. Participants were encouraged to sit apart from one another, and when finished, they submitted their questionnaires in boxes at the front of the classroom to ensure anonymity.

TABLE 1
Acceptable Number of Past Sexual Partners for a Dating Partner, in
Percentages ($N = 147$)

Maximum number of partners	Percentage	Cumulative percentage
11 or more	10	10
10	13	22
9	1	23
8	2	25
7	1	26
6	3	29
5	19	48
4	9	56
3	17	73
2	16	89
1	6	95
0	5	100

RESULTS

Sexual importance. Seventeen percent of the women reported that sex was "very important," 58% reported that sex was "somewhat important," 17% reported that sex was of "little importance," and 7% reported that sex was "not important."

Maximum acceptable level of partner's sexual experience. Almost all (95%) of the women were willing to accept a partner who had experienced intercourse with at least one partner (see Table 1). Only 10% of the women were willing to accept a partner who had had intercourse with 11 or more partners. Almost one half (48%) were willing to accept a partner who had had up to five previous sexual partners. Seventy-three percent were willing to accept a partner who had had up to three previous partners.

Do women choose nice guys? When given the choice between John, an inexperienced, nice, but somewhat shy man, and Mike, an attractive, fun man who had had sex with 10 women, 54% of the women reported that they would prefer John as a date. Twenty-eight percent reported they would equally prefer dating John or Mike, and 18% reported they would prefer Mike. Yet, 56% of the women knew of other women who had had the choice of dating nice but sexually inexperienced men, but who chose to date men who were very sexually experienced but not so nice. Also, 56% of the women agreed that nice guys are less likely to have as many sexual partners as guys who are not nice.

Hypothesis testing. Women who evaluated sex as less important to them were more likely to select John, an inexperienced, nice guy, as a dating partner over Mike, an attractive, fun, experienced man ($r = -.26$,

$p = .001$). Women who had had fewer sexual partners were also more likely to select John, the nice guy ($r = .33$, $p = .001$). Finally, women who preferred that their dating partners have fewer partners were also more likely to select John ($r = .48$, $p = .001$).

Qualitative analysis. Content analysis of women's explanations for why nice guys may be more likely to have fewer sexual partners revealed that the women saw nice guys and bad boys as differing in three areas: (a) personality characteristics, (b) style of interacting with women, and (c) type of relationships sought with women.

Within the nice-guy category, a dichotomy of two stereotypical personalities emerged from the comments, with the women perceiving the nice guys as either losers or good guys. The losers were seen as needy, weak, predictable, boring, inexperienced, and unattractive. One woman stated, "Nice guys often don't provide the drama and adventure women think they want." The good guys, on the other hand, were seen as having such positive traits as good personality, high standards and morals, and politeness. Nevertheless, nice guys were perceived to be less physically attractive, and this was considered to be a major weakness. One woman explained, "Nice guys are generally not as attractive, and have a great personality to compensate for this shortcoming. Unfortunately, looks, not personality, tend to get a woman into bed."

The women's comments indicated they perceived bad boys to resemble one of four different personality types: (a) The rebel was mysterious, daring, arrogant, and dangerous; (b) The macho man was strong and confident; (c) The fun guy was adventurous, spontaneous, and outgoing; and (d) The sexy guy was charming, good looking, and sexually experienced. In listing the perceived personality traits of bad boys, women emphasized that these traits were desired by many women. For example, one woman stated, "Girls like guys who are mysterious, outgoing, fun. Girls like the bad boys."

The nice guys and bad boys were also seen as differing in their styles of interacting with women. The nice guys were considered to be far more passive with "losers" depicted as lacking confidence and unsure of themselves and good guys depicted as willing to wait for sex because they cared about their partners and treated them with respect. The women explained that nice guys had fewer partners because they were less forward in their interactions with women. One stated, "To me, 'nice guys' aren't as persistent or aggressive and don't use sleazy tactics to add another notch to their bedposts."

Bad boys were seen as more sexually successful in their interactions with women for several reasons. First, the bad boys were portrayed as more aggressive, willing to lie and manipulate to get sex. Second, they were seen as more likely to approach and proposition women because their self-confidence and previous successes with women had made them less fearful of rejection. Third, because of their sexual success these men were seen as being desired by other women and thus more appealing.

Finally, bad boys were considered to be more physically and sexually attractive.

The two types of men were also seen as differing in the type of relationships they desired with women. Nice guys were portrayed as wanting serious relationships and valuing commitment, whereas bad boys were viewed as approaching relationships more casually. One woman explained, "Not so nice guys may be more likely to have a one night stand, even if it leads the girl on." Bad boys were perceived to care more about having sex than about having intimate relationships. They were also seen as sexually unfaithful.

One final relationship distinction between nice guys and bad boys was that nice guys were highly desired by women as friends rather than as lovers. "Nice guys are the ones we always see as just friends, and generally aren't seen as potential partners. In general, nice guys are overlooked when it comes to sexual relationships."

DISCUSSION

The objective of this research was to explore women's perceptions and preferences regarding men considered to be nice guys. Consistent with past research, the majority of the women reported a preference for a nice guy (Buss & Barnes, 1986; Regan, 1998) who had limited sexual experience (O'Sullivan, 1995). However, when asked about behaviors rather than their preferences, more than one half of the women (56%) agreed that nice guys do tend to have less sexual success with women. Also, more than one half of the women (56%) reported that they knew of women who had selected an experienced, not-so-nice guy over a nice, less experienced male. However, unlike Sprecher et al. (1997), who reported that almost all women prefer a "chaste partner" over those with moderate or extensive sexual experience, almost all of the women (95%) in our study were willing to date a male who had had at least one other previous partner.

What, then, is the answer to the question "Do nice guys finish last?" It appears that the measurement instruments used strongly influence the answer to this question. First, research findings to date proclaiming the popularity of kind, sensitive men have overemphasized women's partner preferences obtained through checklists while neglecting to study their actual relationship choices. Although many women report that nice guy characteristics are the most desired in a partner, women's actual choices do not always coincide with what they report they want in checklist studies of mate preferences. For example, although the women in our study reported preferring dating partners with limited sexual experience, more than one third reported having dated someone who had had more sexual partners than they would have liked. These findings show the value of analyzing both preferences and behaviors.

Second, determining success also depends on whether the criteria for success are focused on sexual or relationship factors. More than one half of the women agreed nice guys were likely to have fewer sexual partners.

However, when relationship criteria were used, as when the women were asked about dating preferences, nice guys were favored by the majority. Most researchers have measured women's preferences for dating or marriage partners. However, only a few studies asked what traits or characteristics women might seek in sexual partners. Women emphasize different characteristics as important when choosing sexual rather than relationship partners. For example, although Sadalla et al. (1987) found male dominance to increase women's ratings of sexual attractiveness, dominant men were considered less likeable and not desirable as spouses. As well, Regan and Berscheid (1997) found that although sensitivity, honesty, and kindness were women's most preferred characteristics in a marriage partner, physical attractiveness was most desired in a sexual partner, with women considering nice guy characteristics to be only of moderate importance. The assumption in the literature has been that all women are more interested in relationships than sex. Yet for some women, the sexual aspect of a relationship is primary (Kalof, 1995). In particular, women who are more permissive and who are willing to engage in sex are more attracted to bad boys. Thus, bad boys tend to be more sexually successful with these women. Our study supports previous research which found that women who have had many partners prefer men who also have had many partners (Istvan & Griffit, 1980). However, nice guys are popular among women who are not so sexually active. Thus, while nice guys may not be competitive in terms of numbers of sexual partners, they tend to be more successful with respect to longer-term, committed relationships.

An important contribution of this study is the qualitative analysis of women's responses to the open-ended question "Do nice guys finish last?" Although the expression, "Nice guys finish last," is widely used, research has not addressed what the nice guy construct encompasses. Specifically, researchers have made assumptions about what characteristics are associated with being a nice guy and what these characteristics might mean to women (Jensen-Campbell et al., 1995; Trapnell & Messon, 1996). Our results revealed that differing meanings are associated with the nice guy label. Some women offered flattering interpretations of the nice guy, characterizing him as committed, caring, and respectful of women. Others, however, emphasized more negative aspects, considering the nice guy to be boring, lacking confidence, and unattractive. The bad boys were also perceived dichotomously, as either confident, attractive, sexy, and exciting or as manipulative, unfaithful, disrespectful of women, and interested only in sex. As these profiles came directly from the women's open-ended responses, they provided insight into the women's motivations for preferring nice or not-nice guys.

Simpson and Gangestad's (1992; Gangestad & Simpson, 1990) approach to sexual strategies can be used to explain differences in the women's perceptions of nice guys and bad boys and their preferences for date selection. Women who endorse a restricted sociosexual orientation would be more likely to select nice guys as partners and would be more likely to fear or dislike bad boys. On the other hand, women who adopt

an unrestricted sociosexual orientation would choose partners who are more dominant, assertive, and physically attractive, while considering the nice guys to be uninteresting and unexciting. Our results support these categorizations. Women who had had fewer sexual partners (an indicator of restricted sociosexual orientation) were more likely to select the inexperienced, nice guy over the experienced, fun, attractive man as a dating partner. As well, women who considered sex to be less important to them and women who were less accepting of a partner with high levels of sexual experience were more likely to select the nice guy.

Our study provided two major contributions to the literature on nice guys and women's preferences for dating partners. First, it analyzed both women's preferences and their actual behaviors in terms of selecting nice or not-nice guys. As well, the open-ended format allowed the women to describe their motivations for preferring a nice guy or a bad boy, whereas other research has ignored this component of partner selection.

This study was limited by its reliance on single item measures rather than scales. Further, social desirability may have influenced some of the women's responses.

To conclude, the answer to the question "Do nice guys finish last?" is complicated in that it is influenced both by the measurement instruments used and by subject characteristics. Although the majority of women report a preference for nice guys, these men tend to have fewer sexual partners. On the other hand, bad boys tend to be more sexually successful, perhaps because of their confident, assertive style of propositioning women as well as their popularity and attractiveness. Bad boys fare especially well with highly sexually experienced women who are looking for casual, short-term relationships. Although nice guys may be less successful in terms of number of sexual partners, they continue to be preferred for friendships and committed, intimate relationships. In this context, nice guys do not always finish last.

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